committed suicide between 1996 and 2003 because of debt or fear of failure. The history of social exclusion persists on a gigantic scale. Four out of ten people cannot read or write and the index of human development places India in 126th place.[15]

On top of all this, the current process of accumulation faces two limits that were not present in prior centuries. India cannot offload its surplus population through waves of immigration (as Europe did to America) and it suffers from unemployment aggravated by technological innovation. These obstacles tend to be accentuated by neoliberalism's pressure to make labour markets more flexible and to privatise public enterprises. But this aggression is beginning to be met by a resistance that might alter all of this.

South Africa

South Africa represents another case of a nation developing a growing geopolitical gravitational pull in the wake of the heroic popular struggle that finally buried the old racist political system. But this feat – symbolised by Mandela – gave way to a managed transition which consolidated the supremacy of enriched minorities. The co-optation of an African elite allowed the dominant classes to project themselves anew across the region and facilitate a certain economic growth. The end of the apartheid regime's isolation allowed for the consolidation of a free trade region and consolidated an industrialised economy which absorbs fully 70% of sub-Saharan Africa's electricity.

This strategic relocation explains South Africa's incorporation in the nucleus of the BRICS. Russia and India have a GDP four times bigger than South Africa, and China's is 16 times as large. Even South Korea, Turkey and Indonesia surpass South Africa on this score. Its geographic territory and population are smaller than those of Argentina or Iran and it has serious competitors such as Nigeria in its own continent. However, the post-apartheid regime is the only one with the necessary structures to provide regional leadership.

During the 20th century, South African business combined regional expansion with militarism and racism. The white settlers were converted into a ruling class and Afrikaners associated with the mining industry took on the role of police. They routinely deployed the military power they built up during a period of import substitution policies.[16] With the end of white domination, South Africa's ambitions for territorial expansion have been extinguished, but not the role it plays as the gravitational centre of the region's economy. The new African elite are promoting neoliberal capitalism under the banner of an 'African Renaissance'.

The historical leader of the mine workers (Cyril Ramaphosa) became the